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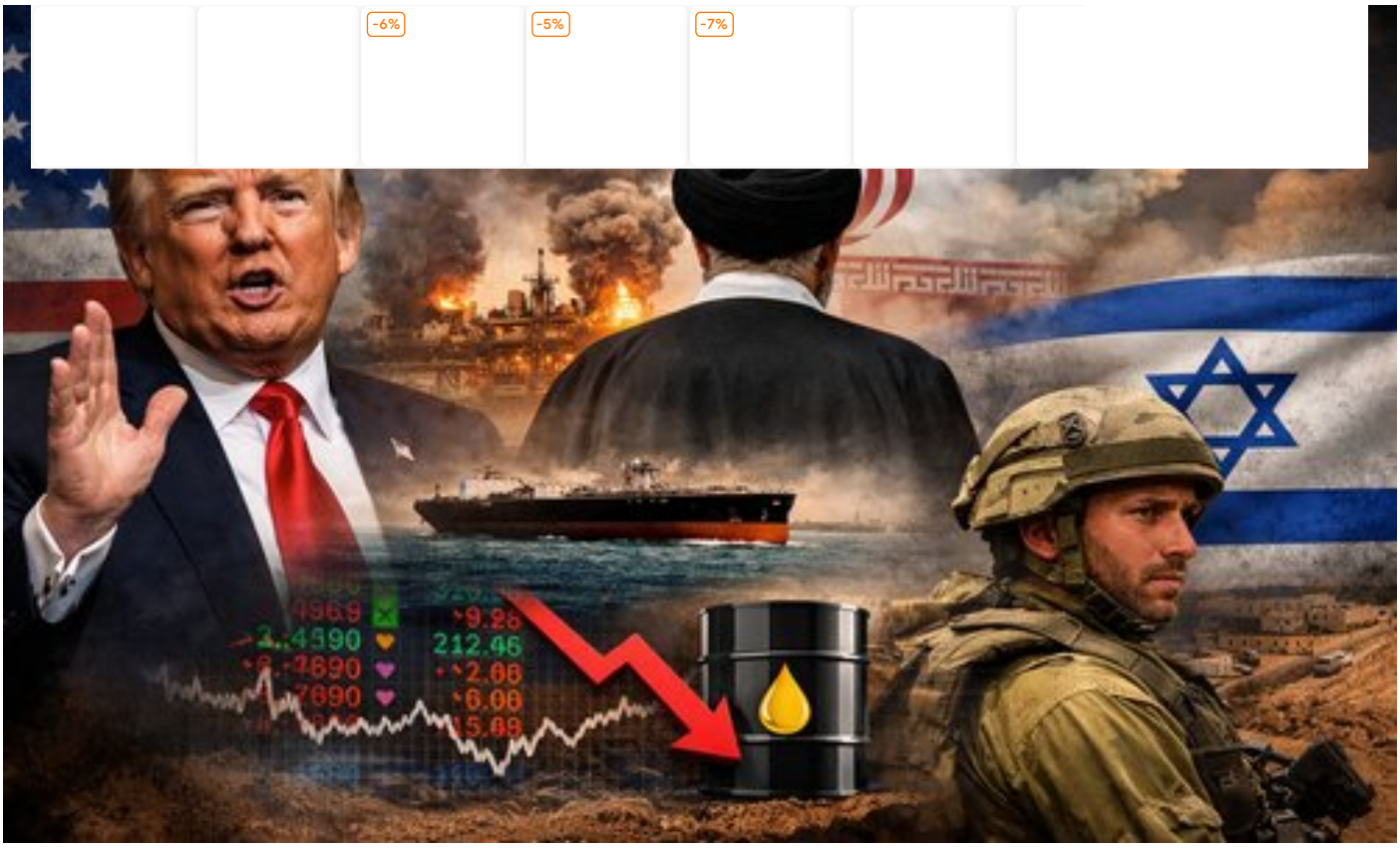
# The Calm Before What? Inside The Strategic Pause In The U.S.-Iran-Israel War



BY PNW STAFF MARCH 24, 2026

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The conflict involving the United States, Israel, and Iran has entered a strange and unsettling phase. The missiles have not stopped. The threats have not softened. And yet, something has shifted. A pause. A hesitation. A flood of conflicting messages that leave even seasoned observers asking the same question: What is really happening behind the scenes?

At the center of the confusion is Donald Trump, who has claimed that "productive" talks with Iran are underway. But Tehran--particularly voices tied to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps--has flatly denied any such discussions. Adding to the uncertainty, Iran's supposed new leadership has yet to clearly present itself on the world stage. Reports and regional observers point to growing ambiguity about who is actually making decisions inside Iran right now.

That raises a critical question few are asking out loud: If talks are happening... who exactly is Trump talking to?

That contradiction is not a minor detail. It is a flashing warning sign that this conflict is no longer just about weapons--it's about control, perception, and possibly confusion at the highest levels of power.

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**A War Fought on Two Different Levels**

To understand this moment, you have to start with a hard truth: this is not a balanced war.

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A side that needs to win fights differently than a side that simply needs to endure. And history shows that regimes built on survival can absorb enormous punishment while still claiming victory. If even a fragment remains, they will say they stood their ground.

That makes this conflict far more complicated than a typical military campaign. There is no clear finish line--only thresholds of damage and perception.

**The "Talks" That May--or May Not--Exist**

Now to the most confusing piece of this puzzle: the supposed negotiations.

Trump has said discussions are happening and even delayed planned strikes on Iran's energy infrastructure for five days to give diplomacy a chance. Iran insists there are no talks at all.

So which is it?

There are three realistic possibilities--and each carries serious implications:

**1. Strategic Messaging (Most Likely)**
This may be calculated signaling. By projecting diplomacy, the U.S. can cool markets, reduce global panic, and buy time to position military assets. A pause does not necessarily mean restraint--it may simply mean preparation.

**2. Indirect Negotiations (Quiet but Real)**
It's entirely possible that talks are happening--but not directly. Backchannel diplomacy through intermediaries is common in this region. Public denial doesn't mean private communication isn't happening--it may simply mean neither side wants to appear weak.

**3. Narrative Warfare (Perception Over Reality)**
In modern conflict, perception can move faster than troops. A statement alone--true or not--can shift markets, influence allies, and pressure adversaries. Both sides may be shaping a story as much as a strategy.

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**The Global Stakes: Oil, Power, and Market Whiplash**

At the heart of this crisis sits one of the most important chokepoints on Earth: the Strait of Hormuz.

Roughly a fifth of the world's oil flows through it, which makes every headline, every threat, and every "announcement" matter far beyond the Middle East.

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That kind of whiplash is dangerous.

Because when markets no longer trust the signals they're receiving, instability becomes the norm. Volatility stops being a reaction and starts becoming a pattern. And in a world where energy prices influence everything from transportation to food, that instability doesn't stay on Wall Street--it hits everyday life.

If no one knows what to believe, uncertainty itself becomes the most powerful force in the global economy.

**Israel's Uncomfortable Position**

For Israel, this moment may be the most strategically dangerous of all.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu is caught between alliance and necessity. If the United States slows its posture, Israel faces a brutal choice:

Pause and risk appearing weak while attacks continue

Press forward and risk tension with Washington

Gamble on diplomacy that may not fully remove the threat

And there is another layer often overlooked: even if the direct conflict with Iran were to de-escalate, Israel's fight is unlikely to end cleanly.

Groups like Hezbollah--Iran's powerful proxy in Lebanon--could continue engaging Israel regardless of any broader agreement. That means Israel may find itself in a prolonged, multi-front conflict even after a "resolution" with Iran is declared.

Israel's doctrine has always leaned toward decisive, preemptive action. A forced pause--especially one influenced externally--cuts against that instinct and increases the risk of long-term insecurity.

**The Illusion of Certainty**

It's tempting to reduce this moment into clean scenarios:

Trump is playing a strategic game

Trump is backing down under pressure

Iran is preparing to concede

But real conflicts rarely follow clean scripts.

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**What Comes Next**

This pause will not last.

Either it breaks toward diplomacy--unlikely but possible--or it snaps back into escalation, potentially wider and more dangerous than before. The uncertainty around Iran's leadership, the contradictions in messaging, and the continued positioning of forces all suggest that this is not a resolution--it's an intermission.

For the United States, the challenge is balancing strength with global stability.

For Iran, it's survival under pressure--and perhaps internal coherence.

For Israel, it's deciding whether to wait--or act, knowing the threat may not disappear even if the headlines change.

Because in moments like this, the silence isn't peace.

It's positioning.

And what comes next may define far more than just the outcome of a war--it may define how wars like this are fought in the future.

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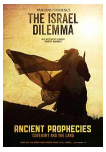


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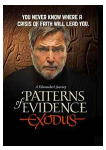


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